

Sacra conversazione

An Italian expression meaning holy conversation, sacra conversazione images became popular in the Renaissance, usually as altarpieces. They are paintings of the Madonna and Child with various saints, often from different historic periods, in a harmonious group around them. Settings are often architectural, occasionally in a garden or an open landscape, and most frequently using linear perspective to create the illusion of an extension to the chapel in which they were housed, suggesting the viewer was actually in the presence of the holy figures.

Most sacra conversazioni have pyramidal compositions, with the Virgin and Child at the top, set back on a throne. Although there is rarely an actual conversation going on, the saints are usually reading, meditating, looking at the Virgin and Child or out of the picture. Artists who produced particularly skilful and harmonious versions include Fra Angelico, Filippo Lippi, Piero della Francesca, Raphael, Giovanni Bellini, Paolo Veronese and Andrea Mantegna.



Palma Vecchio, *The Virgin and Child with Saints and a Donor*, c.1519